

Eye-Gaze Communication App for ALS Patients

User Manual

Assistive Technology for ALS Patients

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1. Overview

This app enables ALS (Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis) patients who have lost the ability to speak or move to communicate using only their eye movements. Using an Android phone (Galaxy phone) or tablet (Galaxy Tablet), the standard front-facing camera — no special hardware required — detects left and right gaze to build a binary codeword (e.g. 01). The codeword is matched to a word (e.g. “No”) or phrase, which is then spoken aloud through the device speaker via text-to-speech.

Unlike conventional gaze-tracking communication devices, which reconstruct words letter-by-letter from an on-screen virtual keyboard, this tool is designed around the small set of words a patient uses most. By selecting whole words with only a few gaze movements, the patient can communicate with far less fatigue.

1.1 Key Features

- Hands-free, hardware-free operation using the device's built-in camera
- Hierarchical word system covering 70+ words across 5 categories
- Automatic Zone 3 shortcut that adapts to the patient's most-used words
- Category pages for Pain, Action, Environ-State, and Feeling
- Text-to-speech output when a word is selected
- Eye-closure pause/resume for breaks
- Customizable vocabulary via the Setup screen
- Optimized layouts for Galaxy Phone and Galaxy Tab
- Full bilingual support: Korean / English — selectable on first launch

1.2 How It Works — the Binary Gaze System

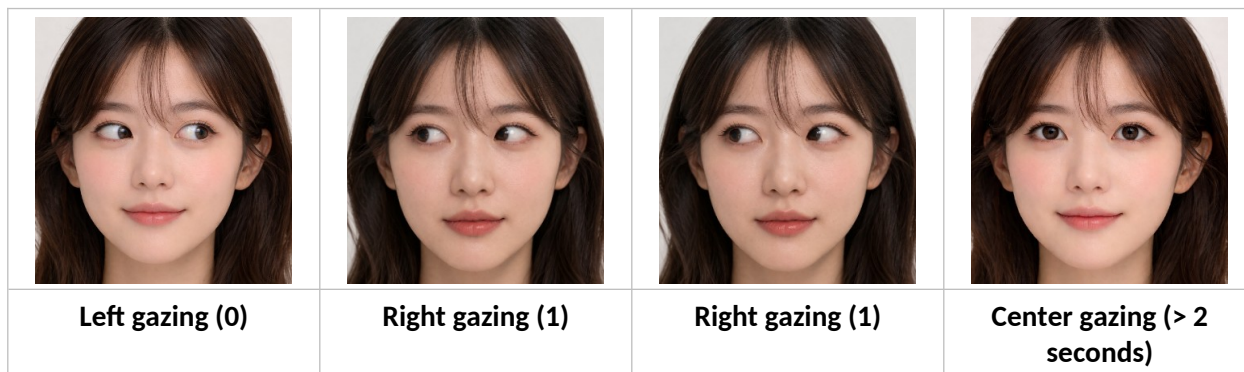
The patient communicates by looking left or right to build a binary sequence. Looking left adds a 0; looking right adds a 1. After completing the sequence, gazing at the center for 2 seconds confirms the selection.

Gaze direction	Bit added	Example
Look LEFT	0	Left → Right → Right = 011 = “Uncomfortable”
Look RIGHT	1	Right = 1 = “Suction” (emergency)
Center gaze (2 s)	Confirm	Hold gaze at center for 2 seconds to confirm

NOTE: For best accuracy, remove glasses before use. If glasses must be worn, adjust the device angle until lens reflections are no longer visible in the camera preview — reflections reduce iris-detection accuracy.

1.3 Example Scenario

For the word “Uncomfortable,” the codeword is 011 (left-right-right). The following images show a person generating this sequence (left/right are from the user's perspective). To complete the codeword, the patient gazes at the center for more than 2 seconds at the end.



1.4 Installation

As shown in Figure 1, mount the phone or tablet roughly 30 cm from the patient's face — positioned so it does not block the patient's line of sight, while still capturing the patient's eye movements clearly.

TIP: Before the patient uses the app, the caregiver should try it out first to become familiar with the gaze workflow.



Figure 1 — Tablet (app) installation / mounting position

2. Getting Started

2.1 Device Setup

- Supported devices: Samsung Galaxy Phone and Galaxy Tab (Android)
- Mount the device so the front camera is at eye level for the patient
- Ensure the room is well-lit — natural or overhead light works best
- Clean the camera lens before use
- Use without glasses, or adjust the camera angle to eliminate lens glare/reflections

2.2 Device Type Selection

On the Instructions screen, select the correct device type:

Device	Typical camera position
Galaxy Phone	Portrait: camera at top-center Landscape: camera at left-center
Galaxy Tab	Portrait: camera at right-center Landscape: camera at top-center

NOTE: *The patient must look toward the phone/tablet camera for gaze to be recognised reliably.*

2.3 First Launch — Language & Disclaimer

On first launch a safety disclaimer is displayed (Figure 2). At the top of the screen tap English or 한국어 (Korean) to choose the interface language — this is remembered across sessions. Read the disclaimer and tap Accept to continue. This app must always be used under caregiver supervision.

Button	Effect
English	Sets all UI text, word dictionary, and TTS to English
한국어(Korean)	Sets all UI text, word dictionary, and TTS to Korean

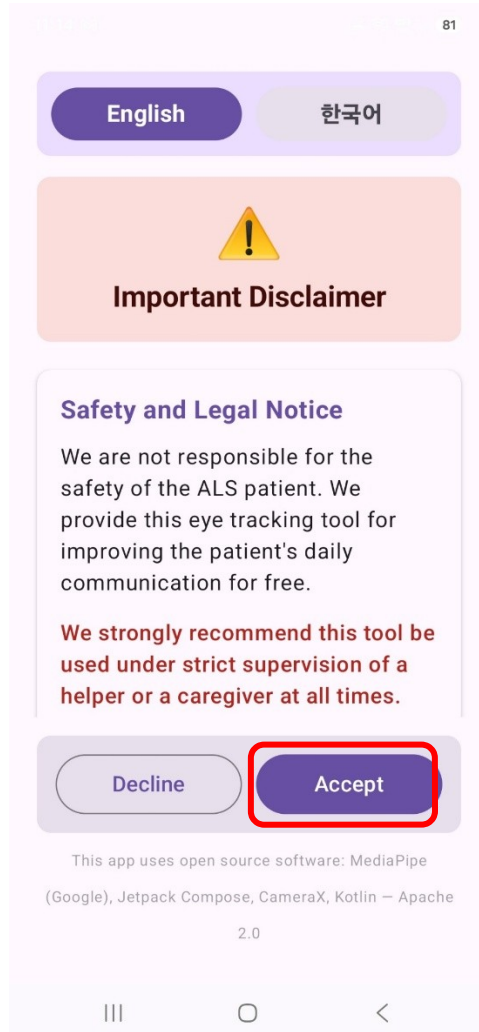


Figure 2 — Disclaimer page

2.4 Launching the Camera

On the main screen (Figures 3 and 4), tap Start. The camera activates, facial-landmark tracking begins, and the status indicator turns green (TRACKING).

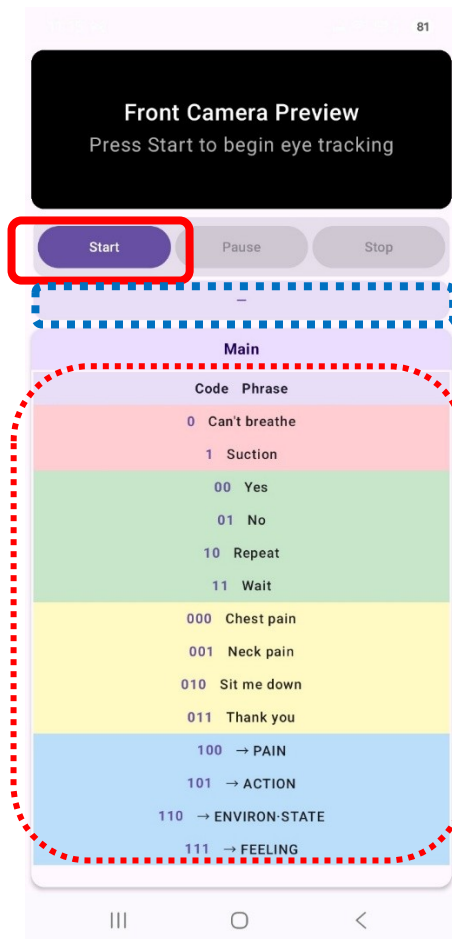


Figure 3 — App main page (Landscape mode)

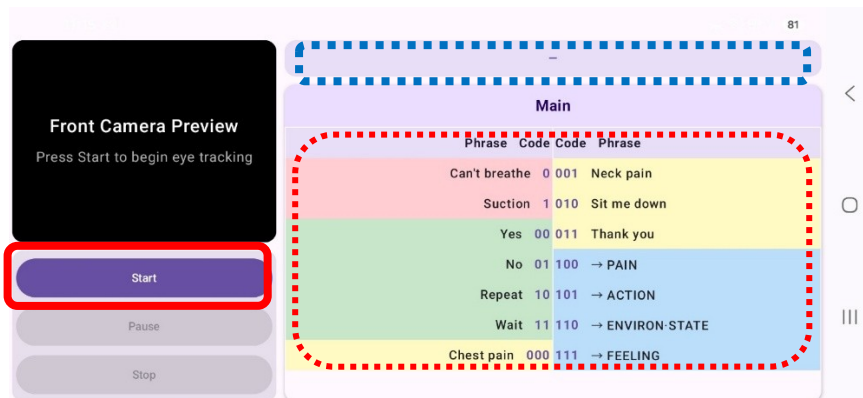


Figure 4 — App main page (Portrait mode)

Button	Function
Start	Activates camera and begins eye tracking
Pause/Resume	Temporarily suspends tracking (camera stays on). Press again to resume. The same pause/resume action can be triggered by closing the eyes for 5 seconds — so a patient who cannot press buttons can pause by closing their eyes for 5+ seconds during use, and resume by closing them again for 5+ seconds.
Stop	Deactivates camera and stops all tracking

2.5 Pausing with Eye Closure

Keeping the eyes closed for 5 or more seconds pauses or resumes tracking without caregiver assistance. The status indicator turns orange (PAUSED). Closing the eyes again for 5 seconds resumes tracking.

2.6 Building Words with Left/Right Gaze (Important)

- The words an ALS patient can use are listed in the main window (shown by the dashed outline in Figure 2). The patient identifies the available words and the codeword that corresponds to each one. For example, the codeword for “Can’t breathe” is “0”.
- Each word is produced by building its codeword through left/right gaze. For example, gazing left then right once each produces the codeword “01”, which corresponds to the word “No”.
- As the codeword is built, each gaze adds one digit shown in the blue dashed area of Figures 3/4, so the patient can watch the codeword being formed in real time.
- After the left/right gaze sequence, gazing at the center for 2 or more seconds completes the codeword. If the completed codeword exists in the word book, it is spoken aloud.
- If an incorrect codeword is formed, gazing at the center for 2+ seconds immediately will discard it automatically when the codeword does not exist in the word book; after 2 seconds the patient can build a new word with left/right gaze. If the mistakenly-formed codeword does happen to exist in the word book, it will be spoken — this is unavoidable.

3. The Codeword System

Words are organized into four zones based on code length (the differently-colored regions [red, green, yellow, blue] in Figure 5) plus four category sub-pages. By design, a single screen can show only 12 words (as in Figure 3). To fit more words into the word book, Zone 3B (blue) is used to select sub-categories: when a Zone 3B codeword is chosen, the app opens the corresponding category sub-page.



Figure 5 — App main page (zone colour map)

3.1 Zone Overview

Zone	Code length	Gaze actions	Purpose
Zone 1	1 bit	1 + center	Emergency words — fastest access with a single left/right gaze
Zone 2	2 bits	2 + center	Meta responses (Yes / No / Repeat / Wait) — selected with two gazes

Zone	Code length	Gaze actions	Purpose
Zone 3A	3 bits (000–011)	3 + center	4 most-used words — auto-updated by frequency, selected with three gazes
Zone 3B	3 bits (100–111)	3 + center	Category triggers (Pain / Action / Environ-State / Feeling), selected with three gazes
Sub-pages	1–3 bits	3+center, then 1–3+center	Up to 13 words per category (code 0 = back to main)

3.2 Main Page — Full Word List

Code	Zone	Gaze steps	Phrase
0	Zone 1 	1 + center	Can't breathe
1	Zone 1 	1 + center	Suction
00	Zone 2 	2 + center	Yes
01	Zone 2 	2 + center	No
10	Zone 2 	2 + center	Repeat
11	Zone 2 	2 + center	Wait
000	Zone 3 	3 + center	Thirsty ★
001	Zone 3 	3 + center	Urinate ★
010	Zone 3 	3 + center	Defecate ★
011	Zone 3 	3 + center	Uncomfortable ★
100	Zone 3 	3 + center	→ PAIN page
101	Zone 3 	3 + center	→ ACTION page
110	Zone 3 	3 + center	→ ENVIRON-STATE page
111	Zone 3 	3 + center	→ FEELING page

NOTE: ★ Zone 3 shortcuts (000–011) automatically update to show the 4 most-frequently used category words. See Section 4.

3.3 Category Pages

Entering a category page resets the code to – (empty). Code 0 (look left + confirm) always returns immediately to main. After any word is selected the app automatically returns to main.

PAIN page (enter with code 100)

Code	Phrase
0	← Back to Main
1	Stomachache
00	Headache
01	Back pain
10	Neck pain
11	Chest pain
000	Nausea
001	Mouth dry
010	Eyes dry
011	*** (empty)
100	*** (empty)
101	*** (empty)
110	*** (empty)
111	*** (empty)

ACTION page (enter with code 101)

Code	Phrase
0	← Back to Main
1	Medicine
00	Change posture
01	Turn me
10	Lift head
11	Lower head
000	Wipe
001	Cover me
010	Call nurse
011	Come here
100	Sit

Code	Phrase
101	Stay still
110	Rest
111	Urinate

ENVIRON-STATE page (enter with code 110)

Code	Phrase
0	← Back to Main
1	Cold
00	Hot
01	Too bright
10	Too dark
11	Too loud
000	Sleepy
001	Itchiness
010	Thirsty
011	Uncomfortable
100	*** (empty)
101	*** (empty)
110	*** (empty)
111	*** (empty)

FEELING page (enter with code 111)

Code	Phrase
0	← Back to Main
1	Thank you
00	Sorry
01	Anxious
10	Scared
11	Sad
000	Lonely
001	Happy
010	Exhausted

Code	Phrase
011	Angry
100	Miss you
101	*** (empty)
110	*** (empty)
111	*** (empty)

4. Zone 3A Adaptive Shortcut

The four Zone 3A frequency slots (codes 000, 001, 010, 011) automatically update to show the patient's most-used words from any category page.

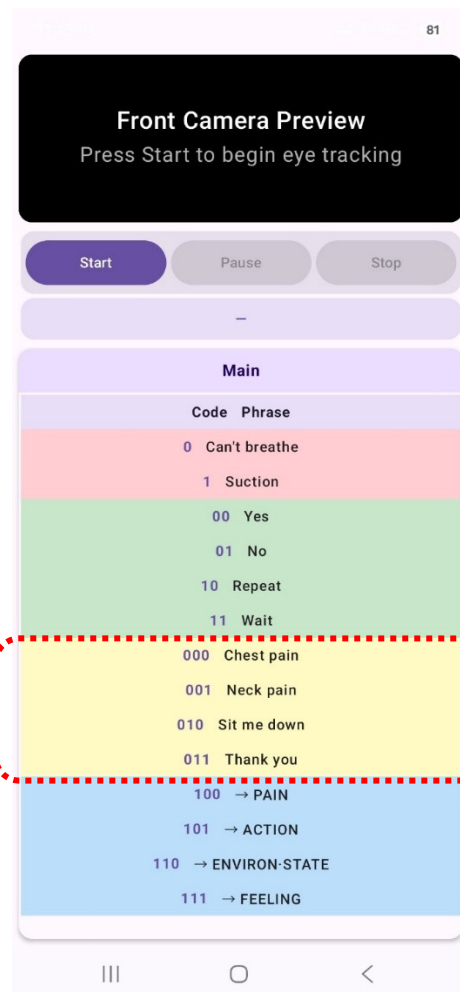


Figure 6 — Zone 3A shortcut display

4.1 How Frequency Tracking Works

- Each time a word is selected from a category page, its usage count increases by 1
- Counts are saved to the device and persist between sessions
- After every selection the Zone 3A slots are recalculated and updated immediately
- The four highest-count words appear in Zone 3A in descending order
- If fewer than 4 words have been used, defaults fill the remaining slots: Thirsty, Urinate, Defecate, Uncomfortable

4.2 Viewing and Resetting Counts

Open Setup and scroll to the yellow Zone 3A — Usage Frequency panel. Tap Show to expand: this displays the current Zone 3A shortcuts with their usage counts and the overall top 10 words. To reset all counts, tap Reset all usage counts.

5. Setup Screen

The Setup screen allows caregivers to customize the vocabulary — words can be added to or removed from the word book. To add or remove words, tap Setup on the Instructions screen (Figures 7 and 8).

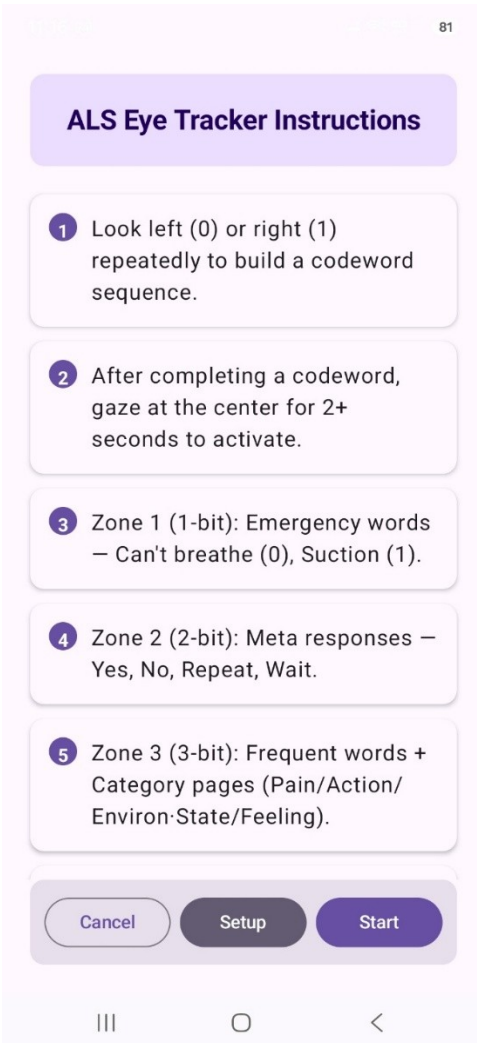


Figure 7 — Instruction screen — before entering Setup

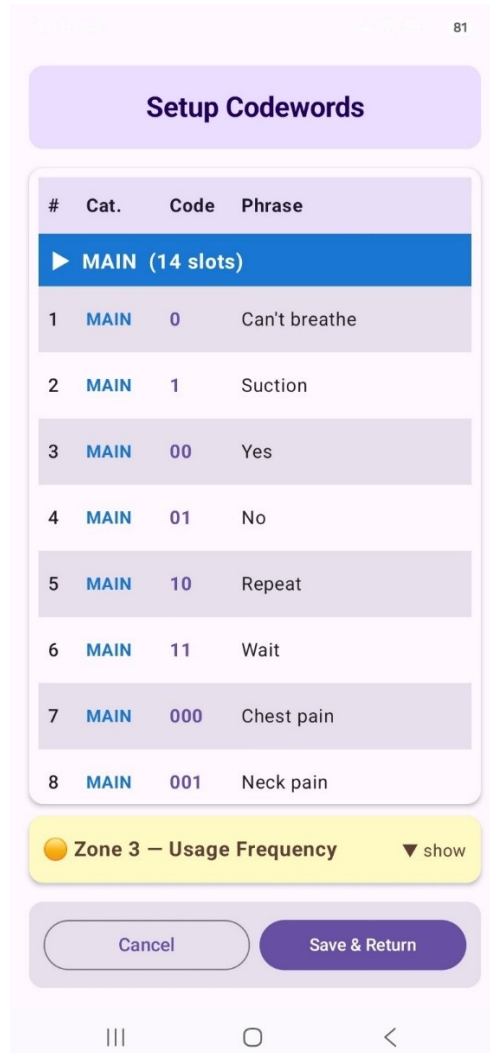


Figure 8 — Setup page — after entering Setup

5.1 Navigating the Word List

Words are grouped by category with color-coded headers:

Color	Category	Contains
Blue	MAIN	Emergency, meta, Zone 3 shortcuts, category triggers
Red	PAIN	14 pain / symptom slots
Dark blue	ACTION	14 caregiver action slots
Green	ENVIRON-STATE	14 environment / condition slots
Orange	FEELING	14 emotional expression slots

Each category has exactly 14 slots for codes 0, 1, 00, 01, 10, 11, 000, 001, 010, 011, 100, 101, 110, 111. Empty slots show *** in grey.

5.2 Editing a Word

- Tap any row to open the Edit dialog
- Type the new phrase and tap Save
- To clear a word back to ***, tap Clear (set to ***)
- Tapping an empty slot shows the Add new word dialog — type the phrase and tap Save
- Tap Save & Return to write all changes to storage

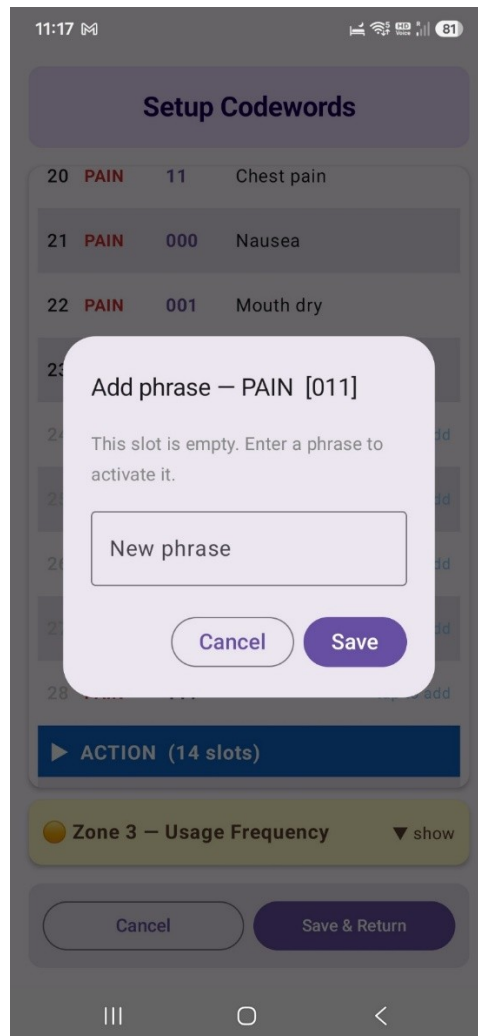


Figure 9 — Add-word dialog popup after tapping a row

NOTE: Changes take effect on the main screen immediately. Closing with Cancel discards all changes.

5.3 Words That Cannot Be Edited

- Code 0 on main page: Can't breathe (emergency — always fastest access)
- Code 0 on any category page: Back to Main (navigation — essential)
- Codes 100–111 on main page: category page triggers

6. Screen Layout

6.1 Galaxy Phone — Landscape

Left region	Right region
Camera preview (left 1/3), Start / Pause / Stop buttons	Status bar, Code table (right 2/3, two-column)

6.2 Galaxy Phone — Portrait

Top to bottom:

- Camera preview (top)
- Start / Pause / Stop buttons
- Status bar
- Code table (portrait, most of screen)

6.3 Galaxy Tab — Landscape

Top region	
Camera preview (top-left 2/3)	Controls (top-right 1/3)
Status bar + Code table (bottom, large text, two-column centered)	

6.4 Galaxy Tab — Portrait

- Camera preview (top)
- Start / Pause / Stop buttons
- Status bar
- Code table (large text, centered, most of screen)

NOTE: In Galaxy Tab portrait mode, the front camera can be far from the camera view, which may reduce recognition accuracy. Landscape mode is recommended for the Galaxy Tab.

On Galaxy Tab, text is enlarged approximately 1.7× and aligned toward the screen center. In landscape mode the left column is right-justified and the right column is left-justified so content converges toward the center, minimizing unnecessary left-right eye movement.

7. Step-by-Step Examples

7.1 Saying “Can't breathe” (emergency)

Step	Action
1	Look LEFT (adds bit 0)
2	Gaze at center 2 s → “Can't breathe” is spoken

7.2 Saying “Headache” via PAIN page

Step	Action
1	Look RIGHT → LEFT → LEFT (builds code 100 — PAIN trigger)
2	Gaze center 2 s → PAIN page opens
3	Look LEFT → LEFT (builds sub-code 00)
4	Gaze center 2 s → “Headache” spoken → app returns to Main

7.3 Returning to Main page from a category

Step	Action
1	Look LEFT (builds sub-code 0)
2	Gaze center 2 s → returns to Main (no speech output)

7.4 Saying “Thank you”

Step	Action
1	Look RIGHT → RIGHT → RIGHT (builds code 111 — FEELING trigger)
2	Gaze center 2 s → FEELING page opens
3	Look RIGHT (builds sub-code 1)
4	Gaze center 2 s → “Thank you” spoken → app returns to Main

8. Tips and Best Practices

8.1 Camera Positioning

- Camera should be at the same height as the patient's eyes
- Keep the patient's face within the center of the camera frame
- Avoid back-lighting (e.g. a window behind the patient) — position light sources in front of the patient
- Distance: approximately 30 cm
- To avoid blocking the patient's line of sight, mount the phone or tablet slightly above eye/face level

Eyeglasses: For best tracking accuracy, remove glasses before use if possible. If glasses must be worn, adjust the device or head angle slightly until reflections (glare) from the lenses are no longer visible in the camera preview. Reflections interfere with iris detection and reduce accuracy.

8.2 Training New Users

- Start with Zone 1 and Zone 2 (1-2 bit codes) and practice until consistent
- Introduce Zone 3A shortcuts once Zones 1 and 2 are reliable
- Introduce category pages one at a time
- Short sessions (10-15 minutes) are better than long ones when starting out

8.3 Optimising Zone 3A

- Use category pages regularly — Zone 3A adapts automatically after real use
- Review the Usage Frequency panel weekly via Setup → Zone 3A — Usage Frequency

8.4 Adding Custom Words

- Open Setup and tap any *** slot to add a custom phrase
- Keep phrases short (1-3 words) for clear TTS output

8.5 Gaze Sensitivity

If the system is not registering gaze correctly:

- Increase room lighting
- Ensure the patient's eyes are fully visible (no drooping eyelids)
- Wipe the camera lens
- Check that the device has not been moved from its original position

9. Troubleshooting

Problem	Solution
Camera does not start	Grant camera permission: Android Settings → Apps → ALS Eye-Gaze → Permissions
No speech output	Check device volume (physical volume buttons). Verify the TTS engine: Android Settings → General Management → Language & Input → Text-to-Speech
Gaze not detected	Improve lighting. Clean lens. Move patient closer. Remove glasses if possible; if not, adjust device angle to eliminate lens reflections
Tracking too sensitive	Make sure the eyelids are not half-closed. Ordinary small eye movements should not enter a code
Wrong word selected	Use Repeat (10) or Wait (11) to signal the caregiver, then re-enter the intended code
Zone 3 shows unexpected words	Setup → Zone 3 — Usage Frequency → Reset all usage counts to restore defaults
Words shown in wrong language	Return to the Disclaimer screen and re-select the language to reload the correct default dictionary

10. Safety Notice

This application is an assistive communication aid only. It is not a medical device and must not be used as the sole means of alerting caregivers to emergencies. Always ensure a caregiver is present and monitoring the patient during use.

- The app must be used under caregiver supervision at all times
- Do not rely solely on this app for emergency communication — always have a backup alert method
- The developers are not liable for any consequences arising from use of this application
- Obtain a speech-language pathology evaluation before introducing this system for extended use

By using this application, you acknowledge and accept all risks associated with its use.

Questions, problems, or feedback: contact.eyyum@gmail.com

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